The Move of the Holy Spirit In North India
by Luis Bush

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Press Release – Religion Today

A Moment in Time — The time is ripe for spiritual harvest in North India by Luis Bush (the Feature Story of *Religion Today*, 28 July 1998

Churches, missions workers, and evangelists are poised to bring revival to spiritually dark North India. …"There are indications that God is moving there as never before," Luis Bush of AD2000 and Beyond Movement said. North India has been called a graveyard for Christian missions because of the strong Hindu influence. …

A kairos moment-an open window of opportunity-exists for Christian ministry in the area known as the North India-Hindi belt, Bush said. "Practically everything flows from this area of the country." The region stretches across north and central India and covers nine states, including Delhi, the capital. It is a major population center and two of the states, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, have more people than most countries. …"All the signs are there.

North India is poised to receive an outpouring of grace and glory," Bush said. Churches are multiplying rapidly and thousands of people are becoming Christians in areas that had little or no Christian witness. Ministries are forming a vision and strategy for spreading the message of Christ into every area and ethnic group in hundreds of districts.

Ministry networks include mainline churches, charismatic churches, international missions organizations, indigenous evangelistic groups, and lay people. …Thousands of church workers attended Harvest Consultations in nine states in July to dedicate themselves to planting churches in areas that don't have one. Evangelists, pastors, and missions workers from Delhi, Jammu, Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh gathered in their states to share information, pool resources, and form partnerships. Participants pledged to target unreached ethnic groups, language groups, urban areas, and geographic districts with the gospel. …

The leaders shared testimonies of church growth. Churches have increased by 15% a year since 1992 in Himachal Pradesh. The state is known to be one of the least-evangelized in India, but people are more open to the gospel than ever, leaders said. About 130 churches have been started there since 1995.

One missionary has baptized 600 people in three years. Radeep, the son of a missionary, prayed for a woman to be delivered of an evil spirit in front of hundreds of people at a bazaar in Kinnaur, the state capital. The next day, many sick people gathered outside the missionary's home to ask for prayer. Since then "the local hospital has been emptied" and a vital church started in Kinnaur, AD2000 said. …

Workers with Every Home for Christ have formed more than 800 home groups in Rajasthan since 1992. They have visited every home in every village and every town twice with the gospel message and are conducting a third outreach, director Sam Lal told the conference.

Evangelists from the Rajasthan Bible Institute started 250 churches with 10,000 believers in less than a year, and they add about 125 new members every month. …Ministries are forming new churches in the slums of Delhi. About 60% of the population live in areas with no water or electricity, AD2000 said. … The group has planted three churches and baptized more than 300 people since 1992. Another ministry has started more than 50 cell churches in the slums…

About 1,500 churches have been started in Madhya Pradesh since 1993, AD 2000 said. About 200 churches have been planted in Bhopal, the state capital, in five years. The state is the largest in India, a stronghold of Hinduism, and is the home of Saktism and Saivism, the worship of two of Hinduism's main deities. It hosts the Kumbh Mela festival, which attracts millions of Hindus to the Ganges River every 12 years.

During the July conference, Christian leaders walked through Bhopal praying that the influence of Hinduism and other religions would be lessened and that people would be open to hear the message of Christ."

THE MOVE OF THE HOLY SPIRIT IN THE HINDI WORLD

The move of the Holy Spirit in the Hindi speaking world resembles the move of the Holy Spirit in the book of Acts.

…and the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved. (Acts 2:47)
… the church was earnestly praying to God (Acts 12:5)
…the word of God continued to increase and spread (Acts 12:24)
…accredited by God to you by miracles, wonders and signs, which God did among you through him, (Acts 5:28)
…on that day, a great persecution broke out against the church (Acts 8:1)
… then the church throughout … (North India) … was strengthened; and encouraged by the Holy Spirit, it grew in numbers, living in the fear of the Lord. (Acts 9:32)

THE MOVE OF THE HOLY SPIRIT IN THE BENGALI WORLD

"Ask of me, and I will make the nations (people groups) your inheritance, the ends of the earth your possession."(Psalm 2:8)

Historic day for the Mobilisation of God's people for the Evangelisation of Delhi

Introduction:

The mobilization event was chaired by Delhi Harvest Network Coordinator Rev Richard Howell, who serves as the General Secretary of the Evangelical Fellowship of India (EFI). Following an extended time of worship and intercession, Dr Luis Bush, International Director of the AD2000 & Beyond Movement, opened the gathering with a message from Ephesians 4 focusing on the ground for unity and the gifts for unity in support of the goals for unity, to extend the Kingdom of God throughout Delhi. He challenged everyone with "Are you ready to give your life, your gifts, your all for Delhi?"

The meeting was held with the backdrop of growing pressures being exerted on the minority communities in the country. On the same day of the consultation the headlines of the Indian Express newspaper read: "Delhi's BJP Govt wants churches off religious places list -- 'Because wine is served there, why can't church be excluded, says Excise Minister."

As participants heard from various church and ministry leaders, a growing spirit of expectancy, joy and responsiveness emerged as they listened to the many things God is doing in Delhi through His people - mostly over the last seven years.

Summary observations of what God is doing in Delhi that out of the models presented were as follows:

1. The importance of Delhi was emphasised as the capital and political power centre of the largest democracy in the world and the country which soon will be the most populous country on earth with one sixth of the world's population.
2. Of the population of Delhi expected to be 11 million by 2000, some 80,000 call themselves Christians per the official census taken in 1991. However, only about 20,000 go to church.
3. Six out of ten people in Delhi live in slums and the number is growing so that by the year 2000 it will be eight out of ten. A slum is defined as a place where basic civic amenities such as water and electricity are not available.
4. Many refugees from places such as Afghanistan, Iran, Tibet as well as migrants from Bangladesh and Nepal have poured into Delhi. West Bengal has come to Delhi - one out of every five Delhites are Bengali peoples. 50,000 Nepali people have made their way to Delhi mostly in pursuit of work.
5. Delhi provides a seed-bed for equipping people for the mission field of Delhi, North India and beyond. Sunil Kapur, an African with historic family roots in India, challenged the participants to come and help reach over three million Indian peoples living in the African continent.
6. Initial results of a survey conducted by the Delhi Harvest Network revealed that there are at least 154 churches and organisations working in Delhi.

Common streams emerging as trends of what God is doing and noted include:

1. Significant new initiatives are being taken to establish the church and present the gospel to the different linguistic and ethno-cultural groups. An Urdu-speaking Muslim believer reported on behalf of the Jumma Masih Worship Fellowship of the responsiveness of the Bengali Muslims and the plan to establish twenty new congregations among Bengali Muslims. Outreach to Afghan refugees is reaching three different people groups among whom a church has been established. There are many new believers among the Balmiki, Sindhi, Punjabi and middle class Hindus. and many baptisms among these groups. Twelve Nepali churches have sprung up in which the vision to

reach out cross-culturally to other groups in Delhi is growing, according to Dr Cindy Perry, Coordinator for the Himalayan AD2000 Movement.

2. Compassionate outreach is growing in the slum areas and development colonies. Abraham Sahu was called to work among the slums in 1991 and has seen many cell groups throughout Delhi. His vision is to establish a worshipping community in each slum and assist in income generation and education programmes. In 1992 Rodrick Gilbert and a few others sensed a heavy presence of the powers of darkness as they walked in the slums. "The Lord led us to fast and pray for eight days. Suddenly we saw the hand of the Lord in deliverance of a number of people from demon possession.", Gilbert reported. With an emphasis on the prominence of the Word of God and the importune of the Holy Spirit, Deliverance Ministry was launched. They have divided Delhi into five sections, each section into ten zones. By 1998 there were three emerging churches, 14 full time staff and 70 volunteers. To date, 326 people have been baptised in the Deliverance Church.
3. Home cell groups have emerged as a widely accepted approach to experience and expand the realities of Jesus Christ in both local churches and Christian ministries in Delhi. In one ministry among the slums in the last five years 50 functioning cell groups have emerged. Several churches both historic and new are emphasising the importance of cell groups.
4. While renewal is coming to some of the historic churches, new wineskins are emerging. Three years ago, Rev M.P. Singh was called to pastor a large Church with only 30-40 attendants from some 46 families. Today this has become the largest Methodist Church in the city with a vibrant ministry having 200-300 attendants from some 125 families of a mixed and middle class groups, now setting up 20 new cell groups in homes of the Church members. One of the new wineskins is Living Faith Community Church which began in 1996 when two young Christians met under a street light to discuss what mission was all about. "There is a desperate need for the church to live out the presence of God in the community. They concluded that the most effective way to reach Delhi with the gospel is through cells and have grown from 11 people to three congregations in cell groups over the last eighteen months.
5. The importance of networking rather than each church/ministry working on their own would enhance the total impact of the body of Christ. The North India Harvest Network was recognised as a helpful vehicle to continue to function as a loose network of individuals and ministries, missions and churches committed to evangelism and church planting in Delhi. It was reaffirmed that the North India Harvest Network or the Delhi Harvest Network is merely the forum for us to come together for this common purpose.

Plans for the future out of the interactive sessions in the concluding sessions included the following:

1. Flow with the existing ministry initiatives in tapping resources and following up on what God is doing at the present time.
2. Call a meeting of committed believers in Delhi for a time of seeking God for the answer to the question "Where do we go from here?
3. Encourage the small ministries and individual initiatives to develop.
4. Complete the research of the harvest force and the harvest field.
5. Prepare a plan to focus spiritual ministry resources on the PIN CODES of Delhi that do not have a church.

Reach Kashmir 2000 Harvest Force Consultation

Introduction:

Some 600 committed believers came together at night and 250 church and mission leaders and grass roots church planters of almost every organization and from every geographical area in the state met in the day from 5-7 July 1998 at Dogra Hall in Jammu. The banner over the platform presented the theme and vision: "Reach Kashmir 2000, Harvest Force Consultation," "Hand in Hand to ensure" "A church for every people and the gospel for every person in Jammu and Kashmir by 2000 A.D."

A spirit of worship, intercession and faith prevailed in our midst. During the course of the gatherings there was a spontaneous time of reconciliation, extended periods of fervent worship directed by Wilson George, interactive times of sharing vision of what God was saying to each participant and small group activity. There was an intensive time of spiritual warfare.

Timothyos Joseph welcomed everyone to the consultation followed by introductory remarks by chairman C. George who shared on the importance of prayer in seeing the release of people for God. "So far you have asked nothing…" (John 16:12) What a shame… Shall we ask "Oh Lord Give Jammu and Kashmir as our inheritance." The inaugural message was given by Luis Bush on five steps to see the state filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. (Habakkuk 2:14)

Alex Abraham presented the harvest survey report. Cody Watson, Doris Bush and Sunil Kapur presented biblical and practical challenges. The focus of the consultation was networking to gather the harvest.

I. Harvest Field Status:

There are fourteen districts, 119 blocks each with about 100,000 people, 282 Pincodes each with about 25,000 people, 165 people groups and 75 language groups and 6788 villages and the urban colonies. There are still three out of the fourteen districts without a single church which are Kargil, Badgam, and Kupwara. The estimated population for 1995 is 8.3 million of which there are only an estimated with only 0.14% of Christians. In the 1981 census there were about 2 Million Hindus and 4 Million Muslims.

This state, most strategically situated in the extreme northwest of India has been and still is a headache to the government and the people of the country since 1947, the year in which India became a sovereign nation. To it's west is Pakistan, to the north China and to the East Tibet, all three fighting battles with Pakistan and one with China resulting in the loss of good chunk of land. And now for at least one decade it is ravaged by nearly two dozen militant outfits for reasons known and unknown making the life of the people totally miserable and painful and the work to advance the gospel very difficult.

The state of Jammu and Kashmir which had earlier been under Hindu rulers and Muslims sultans, became part of the Mughal Empire under Akbar. After a period of Afghan rule from 1756, it was annexed to the Sikh kingdom of the Punjab in 1819. After the decisive battle of Sabroon in 1846 Kashmir was made over to Maharaja Gulab Singh under the Treaty of Amritsar. British supremacy was recognised until the Indian Independence Act 1947.

When all the states decided on accession to India or Pakistan, Kashmir asked for stand-still agreements with both. In the meantime, the state became the subject of an armed attack from Pakistan and Maharaj acceded to India on 26 October, 1947.

Another round of war between the two countries in 1965 was followed by the Tashkent Declaration in January 1966. Following the liberation movement in the former eastern wing of Pakistan, Pakistan attacked India in December 1971. Once again violence prevailed between 1989-1991 during which time Kashmir extremists sought independence with assistance from Pakistan. In 1992 forces for independence within the state waned though Pakistan paid mercenary terrorists from Afghanistan, Bangladesh and other countries continued to inject fear and cause massive refugee movements until the present time.

II. Harvest Force Status:

There has been Christian presence in this state from the year 1885 with the arrival of the Scottish Mission and then by the Anglicans in 1886. For some years the Moravian missionaries were also present in Leh-Ladakh. Then in 1945 came missionaries of the World Evangelical Crusade and they continued till 1963. From then it is mainly the indigenous missionaries beginning with Mr. P.M Thomas who are carrying on the evangelistic work in the state.

Operation Agape came to the scene in only 1991. A Jammu and Kashmir Harvest Force Seminar was held on 13th and 14th of November of 1997 . After praying and waiting upon the Lord, participants set a goal of 500 new churches by the year 2000.

In 1998 there are 115 Christian workers. The average number of congregations/churches per Christian worker is 1.45.

III. Harvest Yield in Jammu Kashmir:

There are only 167 Churches /satellite Churches in the whole state as of July 1998. There is a church for every 49.000 persons.

However, the rate of church growth is most encouraging. After almost 2000 years of Christianity there were only 45 churches in 1990. Then an additional 50 churches were established in the five years ending 1995. Then an additional 50 churches were established in only two years ending 1997.
The districts of Jammu and Udhampur are most responsive areas followed by Kathua District.

IV. Harvest Goals:

A CHURCH FOR EVERY DISTRICT BY 1998
A CHURCH FOR EVERY BLOCK BY 2000 AD
A CHURCH FOR EVERY PIN CODE BY 2005

For the states of Udhampur, Jammu & Kathua District a Church for every pin code by 2000 AD. A church for every people group by 2010.

V. Harvest Assessment on how to complete the unfinished task:

The participants divided into groups to answer several questions as follows:

1. What are the hindrances for achieving the goal ?

- Lack of unity
- Lack of resources.
- Lack of laboureres.
- Lack of prayer
- Improper strategy in sharing the gospel

2. How can we mobilise more people for the harvest ?.
- All the believers to be involved in church planting
- Every home a potential church
- Organise missionary conferences to recruit church planters
- Train up lay leaders for church planting.

3. How can we mobilize prayer movement within the state and outside ?
- Identify prayer warriors and intercessors
- Chain prayer
- Prayer cell to be formed in each church
- Prayer walk
- Prayer seminars
- Prayer bulletin on Jammu and Kashmir
- Prayer day for the Pastors in each district.

4. How can we plant churches in unreached areas of the Kashmir valley where the districts without a church are located and the spiritual need is the greatest?
- Encourage evangelism and Church planting in Kashmir valley through social projects such as orphanages.
- Train up Kashmiri Valley believers for church planting among their own communities.
- Organise harvest seminars in the valley to identify God's gifted people.
- Formation of disctrict level networks
- Establish a good Bible Training Institute in Jammu for training of the Harvest Force.

Conclusion:

Some time ago the Coca Cola company set a goal. " By the year 2000 every person living on the face of the earth should taste at least one bottle of Coke " No wonder Coke is now available in every nook and corner of India. If a soft drink company could set a goal and achieve it why not we who have tasted the sweetness of the gospel of Jesus Christ should make a determinate effort to reach every person in this state and country with the message of His love.

The apostle Paul was gripped with the passion and declared his life goal like this " I do not consider my life to be precious to me if only I could finish the race and complete the task the Lord has given me, the task of testifying to the gospel of His grace."

We in the state of Jammu and Kashmir are committed to complete the unfinished task in our generation and set a common goal of have living churches planted in every District, block, pin code and village and colonies so that we can reach all the 165 people groups and 75 language group, 6788 villages and the urban units beginning with and every block by 2000 AD. Please join us to pray that this might be accomplished.

Light is coming to what was known as "the darkest state in India"
Reach Himachal 2000: Harvest Force Consultation
Sundernagar, 8th to 10th July 1998

Sam Abraham
Himachal Pradesh (HP) coordinator: North India Harvest Network

Introduction:

The fields are ripe for harvest in Himachal Pradesh. Church growth in the last seven years has been a remarkable 15% per year. Longer-term national pastors and leaders affirm great spiritual openness. Intercessors traveling throughout the state report of a coming harvest. In the past year great advance in planting the church where there was no church so that from 40 out 69 blocks with out a church today there are only 18 blocks of approximately 100,000 people that remain with no church. There are many signs and wonders that are taking place.

Between 8th to 10th July 1998 the Reach Himachal 2000: Harvest Force Consultation took place in Sundernagar, Consultation with the attendance of 150 pastors, Christian workers from missionary organizers from inside and outside of India during the day which grew to about 200 at night. The theme was the Great Harvest of Himachal Pradesh. A national and international resource team including C. George, Tony Hilton, Luis and Doris Bush, Roy Wingerd, Cody Watson, and Sunil Kapur. Alex Abraham, the coordinator for Project NW 2000 took an active role in support of Sam Abraham and the activities.

The unfolding of the incredible story of what God is doing in Himachal Pradesh emerged during this historic consultation.

I. Humble Beginnings

Twenty one years ago God's burden and vision for the people of the mountains of Himachal Pradesh caused Brother Chacko to resign form the army and move his wife and seven year old daughter, Mercy to Palampur, Himachal Pradesh (HP).

Their reception was cool. The people would not rent them a house. For the first three months they lived in a chicken shed. But they rejoiced in remembering the Lord's humble beginnings in a manger.

Brother Chacko's army background was an asset as so many men in HP serve in the army. Though gradually, the local people started accepting him. In March of 1980 15 people were baptized. Then, in April more than 25 people were baptized. God granted healings and set women free, who had been married to demons. God granted them favor, yet persecution also arose.

Some determined to kill Chacko. But they were thwarted. They would go back complaining he had too many people walking around the house. The Chacko's were surprised to hear of this through the children, for they had no visitors known to them. Rather it was the angels encamping around them. Others who troubled them received punishment from God. Soon the fear the Lord fell on the people of the area.

Slowly, God's work has prospered. 350 have been baptized and 40 labourers have gone into the harvest. Their son-in-law Sam Abraham has surveyed the districts of HP. Now they feel it is God's time to reap the harvest.

Chacko's church in Palampur became the launch pad for Operation Agape in November 1991 out of which flowed the vision in later years of Reach Himachal Pradesh 2000.

II. Why HP is called India's spiritually darkest state—the harvest field

Out of 5.5Million people the Christian population numbers less than one tenth of one percent (.085%), the smallest percent of any state in India. There are probably less than 15 of the 115 people groups which have some kind of Christian presence although it is hard to declare them as reached by any standards.

As you drive into the state a large billboard reminds every person entering that HP is the abode of gods. It is the land of snow, a tourist's delight. It is situated in the north-west corner of India, right in the lap of the Himalayan ranges. It is bordered by Jammu and Kashmir on north, Punjab on west, Haryana on south west , Uttar Pradesh on south-east and Tibet on east.

Himachal Pradesh became a full-fledged state on January 25th 1971 with Shimla as its capital. (Shimla was the former summer capital of the British Indian Empire). It is India's 14th largest state in area and 17th in population. It is one of the most beautiful states of the country where landscaping knows no bounds. Its geographical diversity ranges from green meadows and pastures to the stark grandeur of the Himalayas.

The least churched districts are Lahul and Spiti, Una, Hamirpur, Bilaspur and Chamba. This information indicates where the ripe harvest fields are and where much ground breaking is required.

The most common language of worship is Hindi and English, followed by Nepali, Punjabi, Urdu , and Pahadi language. There are about 35 languages used by the people in this state which shows that there are several language groups yet to be targeted.

III. Vision for HP follows a survey of the land—the harvest force

Rev. Sam Abraham led a research team, which completed the survey of Himachal Pradesh in April 1997. This report, the Himachal Harvest Handbook, was not a small achievement, since this involved rigorous travel through snow and extreme cold to collect data in rugged terrain.

On May 10-12, 1997, a state-level meeting of the "harvest force" was convened in Sunder Nagar to review the data. The attendees committed to help plant a church in every pin code by AD 2000. As a preliminary goal they would plant a church in every block by December 1998. Reports picture a growing church with many new ministries initiated in several districts. Many churches and mission groups have adopted a particular district, block, or pin code, taking full responsibility to see churches planted in such concentration that all people would have access.

From our survey, we estimate that are at least 5000 active church going members in the evangelical churches.

Operation Agape committed a team of 30 people to plant seven churches in seven unreached Blocks within three months in 1998. Rev. Sam Abraham traveled once again through the region in order to update the handbook before an upcoming conference in July.

IV. Assessment and commitment of harvest force: The harvest yield

Summary:

- There are 241 churches in the whole state as of July 1998 and 170 Christian workers either part time or full time.
- The consultation handbook showed a remarkable growth of 15% of the church over the years since 1992. After so many years of Christianity by 1992 there were only 90 known local churches in the state. Since 1992 there are some 150 churches, of which the number is increasing each year 130 of which were established in the last three years.
- Both pastors and workers in the state affirm that the fields are indeed ripe for harvest in Himachal Pradesh.
- There are 46 different Christian groups working in the state.
- The average attendance per congregation 21.5
- The average number of congregations/churches per Christian worker 1.4
- The Population /Church Ratio for HP of a church for every 23504 persons.

Story of Commitment of the Harvest Force:

In November 1994 Shakuntala Mathews had a vision to move from the district of Shimla to Kinnaur. No one makes this move unless God is calling them. It was called a paradise on earth. The Mathews family was happily settled there. Shakuntala had a good job at the hospital nearby. However, the burden for Kinnaur as a district without a single church grew on her. She told her husband Rev. Matthew, who had been a deacon with the Church of North India (CNI) until 1992 and was a servant with the government. He shared her vision. She asked God for a sign of confirmation. Two days later a post card came from a Hindu in Kinnaur asking for Christians to come to his district. Later, when Rev. R. Mathews went to the address on the post card to find the man, he never found that person up till today. They went to the head office in Shimla requesting transfer to the hospital in Kinnaur and received a transfer letter in just fifteen minutes.

A few weeks later twenty two-year-old Randeep, son of the Mathews, was walking in the main bazaar of Poo, capital of Kinnaur when he saw 500 people gathered around a young woman. He noticed the young woman screaming and rolling on the ground. A magician was trying to get the demon out of her. Randeep kept walking by, thinking that nobody would listen to him if he spoke to them. As he was going by he heard a voice say: “Randeep, Randeep, Randeep. If you don’t pray for this young woman I will use someone else.” He was filled with the Holy Spirit and said: “I will go back.” As he was going back he was given revelation about her past.

Ten steps from the young woman he raised his right hand and prayed. The demon left here at once and she woke up. Her parents were there. When Randeep went on to speak to her about her past they were amazed.

Next day the sick were at the house of the Matthews family asking for prayer by six in the morning. As the entire family prayed for the sick others came and they were there until ten o'clock that night. All were healed. The local hospital was emptied.

Over the last three and a half years 6300 have been baptized by R. Mathews. There is now a vital church in Kinnaur because of unusual commitment of the Matthews to the unreached harvest field of HP.

Conclusion:

Reach Himachal 2000 is a vision to see the whole state filled with living Christians by the year 2000.

- A church for every one of the 69 blocks of about 100,000 people each by 1998
- A church for every one of the 424 pin codes of about 25,000 people by AD2000
- A church for every one of the 35 major language groups by 2000
- A church for every one of the 150 people groups (ethno-cultural groups) by 2005

We are approaching the end of this millennium and God's spirit is moving mightily all over Himachal Pradesh. We are receiving a tremendous outpouring of God's Holy Spirit. The Body of Christ here is beginning to grow among us like never before. There is much to do in prayer, preaching and making disciples.

We invite international partners to assist us in the Himachal Pradesh. Come and help reap the harvest in HP. We need prayer. We need workers. We need partnerships to provide financial support for workers. We need a training center for Christian workers.

Praise the Lord!

For further information contact Alex Abraham INTERNET:alex.agape@axcess.net.in

The Prince of Peace is Moving in the Punjab
Reach Punjab 2000: Harvest Force Consultation
Ludhiana, 12th to 14th July 1998

Dr. Alex Abraham
Coordinator: Project North West India 2000

Introduction:

From the early 1980's, the state of Punjab has been witnessing a lot of turmoil and bloodshed and was considered the most dreaded place to live in India. But today the scenario is entirely different and it is one of the most peaceful states in North India. One may wonder what made the difference. Is it the political strategies or military power? For many people, it is one of these that brought peace to this state. But to us who believe in a God who answers prayer, there is no doubt that it is the 'Prince of Peace' that brought peace to this land. Today Punjab is the state with one of the fastest church growth rates in North India with over 5600 gatherings of God's people in different parts of Punjab. The church in Punjab has almost tripled in the last seven years.

With this as background a gathering was called of Christian servants in the Punjab to be held in Ludhiana from the 12th to the 14th of July, 1998. On the final evening of the consultation newly appointed co-coordinator of Reach Punjab 2000 Rev. Koshy said: "We have experienced the river of God's blessing in our midst." Conference host Rev. Dr. Daniel Abraham who serves as President of the Federation of Evangelical Churches of India and of Bethel Bible Seminary said: "What has happened in these days together is without precedent in the history of the church in the Punjab with so many of God's choice servants united as one to reach all of the Punjab."

A highlight of the last evening was when the voices of the almost 600 registered participants with local church leaders which swelled the numbers to 800 in the evenings joined as one voice to read the Reach Punjab 2000, Conference Declaration in Punjabi:

> "We, the servants of God in the state of Punjab, trusting in the grace of God and the power of the Holy Spirit, in obedience to the Great Commission, decide and declare that we will work hand in hand to fill this state of Punjab with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord by planting churches in every village and every colony and among every major people group by 2000 AD."

Already the goals established in 1996 for the Reach Punjab 2000 Project are on track to this point with a church for every Tehsil (Geographical area of 200,000 population) by 1997 and a church for every one of the 118 blocks (Geographical area of 100,000 population) by 1998 already fulfilled as of June 30. Churches were established in the 16 blocks without a church in the first six months of this year. In addition, a church planting movement has been established in each of 20 of the 25 largest people groups.

The next step is a church for every one of the 490 Pincodes by 1999 and for every one of the 12,795 villages and 7,000 colonies by 2000 and to focus on the smaller of the total of 96 people groups. The overall goal is twenty thousand churches by 2000 AD.

A spirit of revival was evident throughout the meetings. The worship times were precious as a new theme song was sung to take the church to every people and the gospel to every person in the Punjab

by 2000. There were times of repentance and a precious extended time of reconciliation. Respected senior pastor and evangelist Samuel, named co-coordinator of Reach Punjab 2000 said: "I am different after this meeting. I believe every participant will go away changed. There were a number of unreconciled things in my life with other servants of God. During the time of affirming one another and making things right I was able to deal with each one of these things. I feel a load has been taken off me." During the last afternoon, many shared their visions and dreams for the Punjab and what God was leading them to do.

On the last day of the consultation spontaneous dancing broke out among the women participants in their time together. As the reflection was shared from Scripture about preaching the gospel in the light of the Lord's soon return, one of the women suggested they sing a song about preparing for the coming of Christ--the bridegroom. As they began to sing a Punjabi Christian folk song, one began to tap rhythmically on a table. Another women asked: "What would we do as the bride getting ready for the coming of the bridegroom?" (In the Punjabi culture it is the bride that waits and the bridegroom often appears on a fine stallion to come for his bride. The previous day the ladies related to the wedding party dance and sing to prepare the bride). They all responded: "We would dance." So they began to dance on and on and on with bright smiles on their faces in celebration and expectation of the coming of Jesus the bridegroom.

I. Punjab and her rich spiritual heritage at a glance

Punjab is known as the breadbasket of India. It appears first in the history books with the coming of the Aryans to India. It remained under the control of Persian and Macedonian rulers for some time and later under the Mauryan Empire followed by the Scythians, Parthians and later under indigenous rulers. From the tenth century A.D the Mughals and later two other Muslim invaders crossed into India.

Punjab is the only Indian State with a majority of Sikhs (more than 60 percent). Hindus make up more than one-third of the population, and there are smaller minorities of Christians, Jains, and Muslims. The official and most widely spoken language is Punjabi, followed by Hindi. About one-third of the population of twenty million people live in cities and towns.

The Punjab has been home to some choice servants of God who have left a wonderful example long after they were gone that has inspired so many servants of God in the Punjab and beyond to this very day. Sadhu Sundar Singh always maintained a fervent and blissful devotion to his Lord, and became a powerful missionary, preaching across India and around the world until he died in 1920. In the Punjab lived a man called Ditt. The Hindus called him an Untouchable. He was short, dark and lame. He was a laborer in the village and also brought and sold hides. He was in good standing in the Chuhras caste there. By the time of his death some 100,000 from his own Chuhra caste had become followers of Jesus Christ in response to his message and example. Another well-known Christian saint who left a deep spiritual impact on the Punjab, India and the world for that matter, was Praying Hyde who lived in Ludhiana from 1900–1911.

II. How Reach Punjab 2000 all started

One of the highlights of the consultation was to hear the words of C. George say on the last night: "This is the day of greatest joy in my life with regard to the Punjab. I have been seeing something unique—an overflow of the Holy Spirit in our midst."

C. George had served with Every Home Crusade 23 years. During the eighties he watched the origin and growth of militancy in Punjab. Because of the tragic and miserable situation there, the Lord put in his heart a burden, to present to the people of that state, the Good News of the 'Prince of Peace'. The way men of this world tried to talk to the people of Punjab, about the need of maintaining peace, challenged him because the peace that passes all understanding and which the world cannot give or take away is only found in the Lord Jesus Christ.

Meanwhile in the Christian Medical College, Ludhiana, the Lord was preparing and grooming up a team of His chosen people such as Dr. A.V. Choudhrie to be the Director of the College and Hospital and Drs. Alex and Annie Abraham who would play an important role in the future.

Back in Kerala in October 1987 C. George and Sam C. Samuel began to pray for God's peace to come to the state of Punjab for one hour a day which later became two hours. Eight months later and ten years back from this consultation Dr. Alex Abraham was attending to his mother at a hospital when C. George shared his burden with him in the hallway of the hospital. Alex had arranged a conference for Christian leaders in the Punjab for August of 1988 and invited C. George to share his burden.

The 150 Christian leaders meeting on that occasion at the auditorium of the Christian Medical College received the vision and challenge of C. George with open hearts. Operation Agape was launched to counter the violence so devastating in the Punjab at that date with the love of Jesus Christ. Amazingly, since that date, the violence has rapidly diminished and the love of God has been communicated from home to home, district to district,and village to village throughout the entire state. It is amazing to see all that God has done since that new beginning ten years ago.

In 1996 as some of us were praying we started asking these questions. Where do we stand in terms of fulfilling the Great Commission in North West India , our promised land? When will the task be completed? How will it look like when the task is completed? These questions motivated us to the vision of Project North West 2000 AD which included Reach Punjab 2000.

Consultations have been held in every one of the the 12 districts. On the 16th of March 1998 a state level REACH PUNJAB TASK FORCE was formed and the following declaration was signed by all the delegates. HAND IN HAND TO ENSURE "A CHURH FOR EVERY PEOPLE AND THE GOSPEL FOR EVERY PERSON BY 2000 AD."

III. Punjab Christianity today is like the Book of Acts

The testimonies of God's servants are like hearing one more chapter from the book of Acts. For example, one of God's choice servants Pastor Karam Chand was working in the police force. After he became a Christian and was baptized he began to get burdened while in prayer to read this portion or that portion of the
Scripture. As he was praying one day he was led to read Revelation 3:20 "Behold, I stand at the door, and knock: if any man hear my voice, and open the door, I will come in to him, and will sup with him, and he with me." Pastor Karam Chand said: "I fasted for two days and asked the Lord to come and have a meal with me. The Lord did not come. Then I took ten days leave from the police force and sat

down in a room and locked it. I spread out a sheet and began to pray. On the fifth day I fell down. The Lord came and woke me up."

It is reminiscent of the testimony of the conversion of the Apostle Paul in the book of Acts and of Punjabi Sikh Sadhu Sundar Singh in 1904. "Late at night, after much seeking and meditation, he saw a flash of effulgent light before him, with a loving compassionate and affectionate person in the center. He at first assumed it to be Krishna or Buddha, but then the person spoke the following to him in the Hindustani language: "Why do you persecute me? Remember, I laid down my life for you on the cross."

IV. A modern day Joshua and Caleb honored at Reach Punjab 2000 Consultation

Foundational to the ability to assess the status of the unfinished task in the Punjab and challenge God's servants has been the excellent research work done throughout all of the Punjab by Mr. Issac Dutta, Research Coordinator and Mr.Arthur Christopher Chief Field Researcher for Reach Punjab 2000.

Issac reported: "It was in early 1996 that we had the first network meeting of Pastors and Christian Workers in the city of Ludhiana. I was greatly challenged when I understood the potentials of God's children working together in reaching the people of Punjab with the message of God's love. In January 1997 I took three weeks of leave from my work in the Christian Medical College & Hospital Ludhiana and started the Harvest Force Survey of Firozpur District. By October the Lord called me to full time ministry and I left my job."

"In conducting the research we had to face many hurdles. Once we were going to Jalalabad, one of the towns in Firozpur District in search of the pastor of a Church. When we were told about one pastor and went to his place, we found that he was out of station. It was an extremely cold winter night and it was already 9:00 PM and we had traveled 140 Km already by scooter on that day. We decided to go to the nearest town Fazilka hoping that we could find one Christian home where we could spend the night. When we reached Fazilka it was midnight and as we were wondering where we could find a place to rest after a hectic day, a drunken Hindu man received us into his home and fed us. While we were spending the night there we were thanking God for the wonderful provisions that he made for us in that lonely place

Many times our team members were drenched in the rain and other times exhausted by the extreme heat of summer. Although we had to travel thousands of miles to almost to every nook and corner of the state we had no major accidents by God's grace.

We want to thank God for helping us to go and spy the land and to present the data before you to help you to go and conquer this land.

A Harvest Force Survey form designed by Church Growth Monitoring Cell of Operation Agape was used to collect the data. In majority of the situations the data was collected first hand from the Christian worker. Our methodology included the following.

- Collection of Addresses of Christian Workers from all the denominations and mission leaders in Punjab

- Personal visit to each and every one of those churches and the pastors to share the vision and collect information on the neighboring churches. The pastors were so greatly encouraged by the visits and many captured the vision and shared their information.
- In places there were no churches our team visited and directly enquired about any Christian workers or churches. To our surprise in many of these isolated places there were Christian workers and gatherings almost unknown to the rest of the world.

We encountered practical problems in actually collecting the data from the pastors such as:
- Many of the pastors are not aware of the Pincodes or Blocks in which their Churches are existing.
- The majority of the pastors do not have any concept of people groups nor are they aware what people groups their church members belong to.
- Some of the Christian workers were suspicious about our motive in collecting the data. Many times it took several hours to convince them about the purpose of collecting the data.

With all these hurdles it is amazing that we could gather around 1000 forms from the fields of Punjab. Having collected the data our next attempt was to gather the Christian workers in each district for the formation of district level networks.

Conclusion:

God blessed our time together beyond any imagining. This was an historic event. As I reflected with a few others on the morning after the conference with regard to the spirit and momentum and commitment level experienced in our days together I have the deep conviction that the goals set could be achieved with the grace of God. I invite international partners to join us to pray, to believe with us and to assist in making this dream became a reality to the glory of God.

Praise the Lord!

For further information contact Alex Abraham INTERNET:alex.agape@axcess.net.in

It Can be done it ought to be done it must be done
Chandigarh and Haryana: Network Conference

Chandigarh 15-17 July 1998
By Prakash Pathi, Coordinator for Chandigarh and Haryana Network

Introduction:

There was a sprit of expectation as 140 registered participants turned up from 13 of the 16 districts of Haryana and from the Union Territory of Chandigarh to network together to reach Haryana for Christ as soon as possible.

All recognized the immensity of the task and the strong resistance in this state dominated by Hindus of the JAT community. (See appendix) They admitted that it was not easy to share the Gospel of Christ with them. Yet there was faith expressed and the realization that nothing is impossible for God. In the past seven years God has been working powerfully in the state.

A survey conducted throughout the entire state confirmed the relative sparsity of Christian presence. There were only 515 churches and prayer cells recorded in a combined population of more than 20 million people. This is a ten times smaller presence than in the neighboring state of the Punjab with the same amount of people.

However, the encouraging news is that church growth has been dramatic over the last seven years. The total number of churches and prayer cells until 1992 was 90. However, the number of churches and prayer cells has been increasing since 1992 totaling 209 which represents a church growth rate of more than 18%.

A covenant prepared at the consultation was read by Prakash Pathi and unanimously affirmed by all as follows:
"We, the Christian leaders of Chandigarh and Haryana, gathered together in July 1998 for the networking conference, do solemnly affirm our covenant to work together in meaningful networks to achieve the goal of a church in every block and pin code and the gospel for every person in Chandigarh and Haryana by 2000 AD."

Other recognized Christian leaders from India provided their own perspectives on the challenge to Reach Haryana by 2000 AD. Joel David, coordinator for the North India Harvest Network, commented: "The task of reaching Haryana is so great and so urgent that it is very important that we work together to do this because no single agency or denomination can accomplish this alone." Lalchuangliana, secretary for the North India Harvest Network, said: "The task of reaching Haryana is so great that we need to make sure we include the less known individual people and organizations involved in church planting into the networking process as well as the better known ones in order to fully involve the entire body of Christ in Chandigarh and Haryana." Special greetings were given by Rev Dr Paul Pillai, President of Grace Bible College in Haryana which has 1000 students and is known as the largest Bible School in Asia, who wrote: "I congratulate the Reach Haryana 2000 movement for their great vision for the peoples of Haryana. Let us pray and work together with one mind and one spirit to see this land filled with the knowledge of His glory."

Alex Abraham reported on the progress of Project NW2000 in the states of Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh and the Punjab in the introductory session, indicating that there is rapid church growth and movement towards accomplishing the goals in those objectives."

The networking consultation provided a venue for Christians from almost all the districts and organizations working in church planting in Haryana. Major areas considered were the harvest field, the harvest force and the harvest vision and strategy.

I. Harvest Field of Haryana

The ancient "Green Land," a region rich in historical and cultural tradition, was once part of the Punjab, but since 1966 is a separate state. It is a land whose hardworking people have made it an area of agricultural and industrial plenty. The 8 million Hindu Jats form the dominant agricultural caste group in Haryana. A fifth of the population belong to the scheduled castes. Buddhism and Jainism were strong in the area till the 7th Century. Later Hinduism reasserted itself. Islam followed the many invasions of medieval times. Sikkhism also made it's inroads and represents 6% of the population.

Haryana is one of the least evangelized states. Hinduism had its origin in Haryana. It is the land of legends and temples and is known as the abode of gods. There are around 300 temples in the Bhiwani town alone. The names of many of the towns are well-known in Hindu Vedas and scriptures. Yet, the gospel of Jesus has not penetrated to many of the interior Haryana villages. The total Christian percentage is only 0.10 % as per the 1991 census. It is a state very close to the capital city of Delhi and so is easily accessible by rail and road.

Languages spoken predominantly are Haryanvi, Hindi, Punjabi and Urdu among the estimated 19 million people of Haryana and 1 million people of Chandigarh. The population of Haryana lives in 16 separate districts, 108 blocks of 100,000 people, 94 towns, 449 pin codes, 6,759 villages and 92 people groups. **(See Appendix with brief description of the five main people groups).**

II. Harvest Force in Haryana

Only 15,700 identified themselves as Christians in the 1991 Census. This represents 0.10 % of the population which makes Haryana one of the least evangelized states in India.

Anil Kumar and Daniel Kamraj of YWAM conducted a survey over five months the results of which were presented at the consultation. They traveled with a team of ten throughout all of Haryana making a personal visit to each of the pastors in the state. They concluded that there are 515 churches and prayer cells throughout the state.

The Status of the Unfinished Task revealed the enormity of the challenge before us:

- There are 92 people groups of which 77 are still outside God's Kingdom
- There are 353 of the 449 Pin Codes without worship centres
- There are 46 of 108 blocks without churches in Haryana
- The least churched districts are Panipat, Sonipat, Bhiwani and Mahendragarh which still does not have a church

One of the major considerations was the preparation of and availability of laborers for the harvest field. There are eleven training centres and 56 organizations and churches working in Haryana.

III. Harvest Vision is Reach Haryana 2000

Reach Haryana 2000 is a vision for saturation church planting and evangelism by 2000 AD. We need to see the state of Haryana filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. To see this happening, we need to see living churches planted in every town, block, pin code and village of Haryana so that all the 92 people groups in the state can be reached by the gospel of Jesus Christ. Therefore a common goal has been considered in this project which is given above.

Secondly we need to see a united movement of all God's people to achieve the target. We want the whole body of Christ to be involved in reaching out considering the richness and the variety of Haryana in the terms of people, language, and belief. Unless we work together as a united effort we cannot achieve this target.

Reach Haryana 2000 Goals:

- A church planting movement in every block by 1998
- A church planting movement in every pin code by 2000 AD
- A church planting movement in every major people group BY 2000 AD.

Reach Haryana 2000 Strategy;

- Collection of Harvest Force Data.
- District and state level network conferences
- Grass Roots Church Planters training
- Mobilisation of Harvest Force
- Mobilisation of Prayer
- National & International Partnership

Proposed plan of action for achieving these Goals

1. Formation of State Level & District Level Network Conferences. In order to bring together the Christian workers in this state, we propose to arrange district and state level harvest force seminars and conferences. We would encourage Christian workers in each district to come together and pray and plan to reach their own district. Formation of State Level Network of pastors and Christian workers will begin with a state level conference in July 1998.

2. Training of Grass Root Church Planters. In order to achieve this goal we need a large number of Christian workers. We plan to mobilise all the church planting organisations in this state to try to mobilise potential church planters to undergo training in church planting. We also need to set up several training programs in the state.

3. Mobilisation of Harvest Force- Encouraging existing pastors and Churches for more effective ministry. We therefore plan to arrange frequent conferences to motivating them to set goals in the ministry and to work towards them

4. Mobilization of prayer - The key to the success of this project is going

to be prayer. We are planning to mobilise in each district at least 100 serious intercessor and thousands from other areas for this project.

Conclusion:

The consultation concluded with a united expression of commitment to contribute towards the goals of a church for every block by the end of 1998. In the final session various organizations adopted a number of the 46 unchurched blocks with prayer for each initiative as follows:

YWAM – 10, Bethel Fellowship – 10, Operation Agape – 10, Eternal Life – 5, Church of God – 5, Full Gospel of India – 5, Assemblies of God – 5, Mission India – 4.

Alleluia for all that God did in our midst during the three days of our consultation!

For further information write to: Prakash Pathi, Coordinator for Chandigarh and Haryana for NIHN e-mail address: Bethel@ch1.vsnl.net.in

Appendix with brief description of five of the main People Groups

The DALITS: Scheduled castes constitute about one fifth of the populations of the state. They are found over the state. The Chamar are the most prominent among them so are the Balmikisb. They are also comparatively more advanced than those in other states. The Scheduled castes are no longer content with their traditional role. As a result of various facilities and special privileges provided by the Government, they are now legislators, Ministers and senior Government officials. Dalits have traditionally been responsive to the Gospel.

JATS: The Jats are admirable cultivators they profess Hinduism and are divided into twelve chief clans Important among them are Malik, Dahiya, Ahlawat, Rathi, Dalal, Kadian, Jakhar, Golia and Deswal. There are about 137 minor gotras. The Jats form a prominent proportion in the Northern districts particularly Hisar, Karnal and Ambala. The Jats are known for their hard work and enrgy and active in politics.

GUJJARS: Gujjars are found in large numbers in Northern Karnal district. The Gujjars are fine, stalwart people. They were originally more a pastoral than an agricultural tribal.

MEOS: The Meos are Tribals. They are concentrated in southern Gurgaon They claim to have a Rajput origin, descendants of an ancestor who was converted to Islam . They actually practice a folk religion which is a mixture of Islam and Hinduism. They observe the feasts of both. On the occasions of marriage, birth and others, they observe Hindu customs.

RAJPUTS: The Rajputs are less numerous. The various clans trace their ancestry to hoary times and claim to have descendants of the Surya-vansis and Chander vansis, whose deeds have been immortalised in the great epics of the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. The Rajputs see themselves higher than other people. They take little interest in agriculture and they prefer to serve in the army.

Rajasthan Ripe for Harvest:
Rajasthan Harvest Consultation
Jaipur, 19-21 July 1998

By T.S. David and Sam Lal

I. The Harvest Consultation – anticipation of a major spiritual harvest

Rajasthan is ripe for spiritual harvest was the conviction of Christian leaders and the more than 200 assembled for the opening evening of the Rajasthan Harvest Consultation on 19th July. This harvest can only be reaped as the various organizations work together. The next day grass roots church planters from many districts in the state totaling some 152 registered participants plus another 50 local leaders making a total of 200.

Consultation chairman Dr. Anand Chaudhari, President of Rajasthan Bible Institute said: "We are convinced that no one organization or church will be able to reach Rajasthan alone. Those days have gone when we were on our own. We are convinced that we must have a network where we will bring workers from different denominations and ministries so they will join in a united effort".

Consultation coordinator Dr. T.S. David, Emmanuel Ministry expressed his hope for the consultation when he said: "My prayer and vision that through this conference every participant will increase vision, increase harvest force and through a joint effort see Rajasthan reached with the gospel. We need churches in every block. Let us unite our hearts and our efforts to see this vision fulfilled."

Sam Lal, Director of Every Home Crusade in Rajasthan, who played a key role in the development of this consultation gave a tangible indicator of why the fields are ripe for harvest in what has happened in the state through the ministry of Every Home. After two coverages of every home in every village and town with Christian literature by 1991 there were 200 Christ groups, or regularly meeting worship centers. However, since 1992 as they have continued their systematic evangelistic outreach 800 Christ groups have been formed in just the past seven years. This vastly accelerating response suggests that there is a higher responsiveness to the gospel and this is the time for a major systematic cooperative effort.

Dr. Thomas Matthews, Native Missionary Movement, whose ministry supports 700 church planters throughout India said: "This is the first conference in the history of Rajasthan which I have attended where we have come together from different ministries in this way. Something great is going to happen."

II. The Harvest Field of Rajasthan

Rajasthan means "the abode of the rajas." The state is a collection of 18 former princely states with more than 46 million people, 90% of who speak Hindi. One third of the population are among the scheduled castes and the scheduled tribes. The largest tribes are the Mina with some two million and the Bhil with almost the same number.

Christians have contributed much to the educational progress of the state through schools, colleges, medical and adult literacy centers that go back to the late 1880's when numbers of missionaries came from Scotland.

There are some 32 districts, 237 blocks of 100,000 people each, 1404 Pin Codes, 39,000 villages and 121 people groups in Rajasthan. The geographic areas are mostly unreached with one half of the Christians in the Ajmer and Banswara districts and the other half distributed among the other 30 districts. Almost all the people groups are unreached with the exception of the Bhils in the south. For example there are no known Christians among the over two million Meo Muslims.

III. The Harvest Force

There are some 70 different churches and missions working in Rajasthan. Through the efforts of the IMA a present status of Christian work in Pin Code areas was prepared in September 1995 that shows which church or organization is working in each of the pin odes in the state.

The vast majority of churches have been established through the ministry of four groups.

The ministry of Emmanuel, under the leadership of Dr. M. A. Thomas has established some 50 churches over 45 schools have been started throughout the state of Rajasthan.

Dr. Anand Chaudhari, founder and director of Rajasthan Bible Institute, has been instrumental in the harvest force through multiple ministries based on a strong radio outreach. Raised in the home of a Hindu Brahman priest, and spared from a smallpox epidemic in India which took the lives of his four brothers, Anand was trained to follow in his father's footsteps as a priest, yet a deep and unfulfilled longing for truth gripped his soul. While studying at Bombay University, he joined the Communist Youth League as part of his search for peace, and during a debate with a Christian, was confronted for the first time with the name of Jesus Christ. This led him to investigate the Christian philosophy by reading the gospels. His search through Scripture led him to faith in Jesus Christ. Although his faith was severely tested by being cast out from his family, he pursued the call of God on his life to reach out into difficult Hindu North India with the gospel. Through a radio ministry, training of church planters, adult literacy centers and literature distribution some 500 churches have been established through RBI over the past thirty years in Rajasthan.

Sam Lal, son of the soil, and Director of Every Home Crusade (EHC) in Rajasthan has trained and sent out many workers for the harvest. EHC has distributed Christian literature to every home in every village and town twice. Now, on their third time they are seeing a great harvest. Groups of Christians are then presented to denominations.

IV. The Harvest Yield in Rajasthan

There are an estimated 40,000 Christians in the state of 46 million or .08% which makes this one of the states with the smallest Christian presence in India.

Three districts in Southern Rajasthan, Banswara, Udaipur and Dungarpur contain some 4,500 villages with a population of two million people, predominantly members of the Bhil Tribe. Twenty years ago,

the Bhils of this area, was a completely unreached people group. However, today there is mighty spiritual fire spreading among them.

Two years ago over 1500 were baptized on one single occasion as a result of a literature distribution programme of EHC.

In May 1996, 19 RBI trained evangelists were reaching into 600 villages, and reported over 4,000 conversions to Christianity in the district. The Holy Spirit is moving in powerful ways, resulting in explosive church growth. Sixty churches and over 100 worship groups were functioning. People walk for hours to attend worship.

By February 1997 the same 19 evangelists were now reaching into 800 villages, and 300 churches and worship groups, averaging 30 to 40 people each, were functioning. There were now 9,000 to 10,000 believers, with 125 people taking baptism every month. Following a church service on Sunday, February 9, 1997, over 300 people took baptism. Stories of God's power at work in wonderful ways continue to multiply. People are being delivered from evil spirits, others are receiving physical healing, and the joy of God's salvation is penetrating their hearts.

In the adjoining district of Udaipur the same signs of the Holy Spirit's moving are evident among the Bhils. At least 80 people are baptized every month in the District, and presently there are about 1100 believers meeting in 16 churches and worship groups. Another 100 churches have been established through the ministry of Thomas Matthews. There is enormous potential for completing the task of evangelizing these three districts in the years ahead.

However, there is growing opposition from Hindu fundamentalist groups in these districts. They are putting pressure on the people to resist the spread of the gospel, and also try to intimidate the workers and Christians. They are also looking for ways to win back some of these converts. Some workers are being threatened with injury and even death. One of the workers at the consultation was involved in a court case for witnessing of his faith in Christ. A Christian leader , when asked about their response to these threats stated, "they might be able to harm us, but they cannot stop the fire from spreading."

V. A Harvest Approach Query in Rajasthan

With the responsiveness of the Bhils to the gospel in Rajasthan yet the neglect of other harvest fields within the state the issue of approach to the harvest with limited number of workers is a significant issue in the state of Rajasthan.

Should we continue to focus on the responsive areas or redeploy our workers and encourage newly trained workers to go to the unreached peoples? We were challenged by the message of filling the earth of Rajasthan with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea.

The North India Harvest Network approach was considered in discussion groups on how to approach the task by 1) the People Group (ethno-cultural, caste) approach, 2) the Geographic Approach which means every village, every colony in every city in every block of (100,000 people) and every district, 3) The linguistic approach, 4) the responsive people approach with a special ongoing focus on the Bhils, 5) the holistic approach. (Christians are known for their compassion for the poor and disadvantaged. Christian missionaries have pioneered in the area of health, education development, abolition of obnoxious social practices, freedom, justice and democracy. We need to help the poor, the sick and the disadvantaged). 6) Combination of the above.

The bottom line question us whether to move into areas of unreached people groups on the one hand or the so-called 'harvest' areas on the other or both. A thoughtful reflection to the question suggested that harvest differs from field to field but all are harvest fields. Rather than dichotomizing 'harvest' fields and the 'unreached' fields is to consider the unreached as a neglected harvest field.

What we must do is to raise up new workers for the neglected harvest fields. At the same time we must raise up local leadership in the responsive harvest fields. In the process there will be a shift of personnel and resources into those gaps that exist as well as into the most neglected harvest fields.

VI. Specific Harvest Goals emerging out of the Harvest Consultation

1. To complete the research of all of Rajasthan by the end of 1998.
2. By end of 1998 should be at least one church in each of the three or four districts out of 32, which yet do not have a church.
3. To establish a church planting movement among every one of the 237 blocks by the end of 2000.
4. To establish a church among every one of 1404 Pin Codes by 2010.

VII. A Harvest Story in Rajasthan

There are many reports of miracles and power encounters in Rajasthan, especially among the Bhil tribe. One of those stories reported by three of the main players in the story who were at the Harvest Consultation could be right out of the Book of Acts.

Limba's father was a village chief and a prominent witch doctor in the village. His father practiced demonic things. His hut had a seat made of human ashes picked from cremation places. Demons started haunting family members. Not surprisingly, Limba was under demonic possession. Sam called it Legion for there seemed to be 2000 demons inside. He was swollen like a very fat person. He would see demons coming at him and chopping him up. He used to scream. His father tried to deliver him but was unsuccessful. He called his circle of friends but they could not do it. So they took him on a Hindu pilgrimage in the hope of cleansing his soul. That did not work. They then took him to the Temple of the Monkey (Hanuman god) next to the Mahi River near to the famous Mahi dam of Rajasthan. By this time Limba was as though dead. He was already bed ridden. They said: Walk seven times around the temple and place him in the holy bath. He was physically sick as well as demon possessed. There was a strange sickly smell coming from him.

After the walk around the temple nothing happened. The Hindu priest said he was a lost case. They advised his father to throw him into the river to get rid of him that his soul might merge with the big spirit of the river.

His father however, brought him home to his village of Dhuliagarh in the Tehsil of Bagidora in the district of Banswara in Southern Rajasthan. Two EHC evangelists Lauji and Gauji came to the village as part of their literature distribution process. They came to know he was sick and immediately came to the home of Limba. They found that a crowd had already gathered expecting him soon to die. When they saw him they lost heart. He was a pathetic sight, in convulsions and death throes. Suddenly they got a ray of hope when they watched with amazement and saw the man come to his senses for a

moment. He started shouting: “Doctors, sir, please heal me because I see many big black giants coming to cut me into pieces.” The evangelists understood that this was more than just a physical sickness. The powers of darkness were snuffing out is life. They turned to the crowd that had gathered. They shared about Christ with them They asked them to believe what God could do and to join them in a prayer of faith for Limba.

The moment they prayed with that authority. Limba fainted, stinking water oozed out of his pores like a boiled tomato that is squeezed. Within a few hours he became thin.

After receiving his healing he was in bed recovering from general weakness. On the seventh day, without anyone teaching him the word he shouted “Hallelujah and began praising God.” Now people thought he had gone mad but in fact he was being filled with the Holy Spirit. Limba has been serving the Lord for twelve years. He became the Timothy to Gauji and Lauji. Both Limba and Gauji were at the consultation. He trained and became a volunteer until 1993 when h became a missionary.

Now if he does not see a miracle per day he questions his life in the Lord. He is still basically illiterate. He has 15 disciples and has spiritual ownership and responsibility over a group of villages in the Dhuliagarh district. His own people call him Maharaj which means priest.

Conclusion:

In the concluding morning session the participants joined together in covenanting as follows:

“We, the Christian leaders of Rajasthan Harvest Consultation, in Jaipur on July 21, 1998 covenant under the enabling grace of God and the power of the Holy Spirit in obedience to the Commission of our Lord Jesus Christ that unitedly pray, participate and provide to see that by AD2000 a church in every block in Rajasthan is planted.”

The Covenant of Rajasthan Harvest Consultation, Jaipur July 1998

For more information contact Sam Lal Mina@watchman.com

The Madhya Pradesh Harvest Network Consultation
Bhopal from 22nd July to 24th July

By Dr. Victor Choudhrie

I. The Harvest Consultation

170 registered participants from more districts than any previous gathering in MP (24 out of the 61 districts) came together in Bhopal from 22nd July to 24th July. Some cycled 300 Miles to come to the conference. Others spent two days in trains and/or buses in order to participate.

The harvest force survey just concluded revealed the remarkable increase in the number of churches from 500 in 1993 to 2000 in 1998 and growing. In Bhopal alone from 42 churches in 1993 the number of churches in increased to 242 in 1998. This constitutes one of the fastest church growth by multiplication of any state in India.

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Reports from what God is doing by the various participants district by district was one of the highlights of the meeting. Street preachers, evangelists, church planters, medical doctors, government officials all shared in common their stories of things God is doing. On the third day of the consultation every body went prayer walking throughout Bhopal.

The participants were challenged to return to their districts and organize district level harvest network meetings as soon as possible.

Information provided for each district has been prepared with a map of the district showing the precise location of every church within every pin code. In addition, high level description of the people groups, the strongholds, Christian presence and how to reach the district for each of 61 districts in the country has been profiled.

In the process of surveying the harvest force over the past six months the approach was to visit every single pin code personally to see if there was any Christian worker – whether full time, part time or occasional. The survey included a visit to the government primary health center and education center to see if there was a Christian nurse or a teacher conducting a small worship group. As each worker in each district is invited to the district-wide consultations, they will be motivated to plant multiplying NT-type house churches.

II. The Harvest Field

Madhya Pradesh (MP) means central province. We were encouraged to remember each one of our central provinces every time we have a meal. MP is India's largest state in size. Bastar, our largest district, is bigger than the whole state of Kerala. However, there are less Christians in the whole of MP than just one district in Kerala.

38% of MP's total population of 70 million consists of 50 different types of tribals and 60 scheduled castes (1991 Census). Together the tribals, other religious groups and the castes total 342 people groups, most of whom have minimum Christian presence. The largest number of Scheduled Tribes in the whole of India is found in this state. In fact this number represents the largest single concentration

of tribals in the world. The central part is dominated by the Gonds (the mountain men). The Western part is dominated by the Bhils (the bow and arrow people). The Eastern part is dominated by the Oraons and Santhalis. All are animistic, mostly dealing with demonic powers.

In outreach terms, Madhya Pradesh presents a ripe harvest field. The tribals are all receptive but there is a real need for national and international advocates.

70% of the Christians live in the eastern part of the state comprised of seven districts which soon will become an independent state. The other 30% of the 70,000 Christian families live in the remaining 54 districts.

Satan has planted his strongholds in almost every village, colony, town, street and household. His methods are those of deception (2 Cor. 11:14), domination (Gen. 4:7), and destruction (John 10:10). The only way to overcome him is by intercessory prayer. A careful study of the strongholds in MP has been made.

III. The Harvest Primary Breakthrough Process in MP: Spiritual Mapping with Informed Focused Fervent Pray

The purpose of prayer is to release the body of Christ and neutralize the demonic powers through prayer walks and intercession

Spiritual mapping in Madhya Pradesh involves the identification of strongholds in the city, village and state. A survey has been completed for MP involving:

1. The history that tells of the religious strongholds and how deeply established they are. Madhya Pradesh is a center of Saktism and Saivism. Saktism is the worship of the female energy and stands for the power of particular female goddesses. Saivism is the worship of Shiva.
2. The centers of Saktism have been located in order to conduct prayer journeys and pray specifically against the structures. Durga is worshipped in the east of the state.
3. The Kumbh Mela (Major Hindu festival every 12 years) is held in Ujjain, a center of Shaivite worship. The next one in 2002 is expected by the Hindus to be the biggest Kumbh Mela ever attracting 15 million Hindus coming in search of salvation. International prayer walkers are invited to prayer walk MP and especially in preparations for this event.
4. With its large numbers of tribals, MP is saturated with animistic beliefs and witchcraft. Each people group's gods has been identified.

Guidelines for informed prayer used in MP

1. Identify who/what you are praying for. E.g., A certain people group in a district, a religious practice, a street dominated by other religious strongholds.
2. Identify with the sins of the locality and ask God's forgiveness. (See Nehemiah's model of prayer. Neh.1:5-7)
3. Put on your spiritual armor and bind and demolish strongholds by calling on Jesus' divine power by virtue of the authority vested in you (2 Cor. 10:4).
4. In prayer warfare, it is important to involve the community. Praise and prayer walks can achieve this. They are based on God's promise to Joshua (Jos. 1:3). Every place we tread will belong to us by faith.
   - Prayer walks. Focus on a neighborhood and walk around praying for its people.

- Praise marches. These are focused on cities. Believers praise God in unison while walking through strategic city centers. The public declaration of praise exalts God's name on high.
- Prayer expeditions. These are taken to open a particular region to God's Kingdom.
- Prayer journeys. These focus on strongholds. Believers pray specifically against the stronghold's powers and claim Jesus' victory.

IV. The Harvest End Product in MP is NT-type multiplying house churches

The goal is to plant about 30,000 house churches by the year 2007. This is the number of Panchayats (cluster of 2-3 or more villages as administrative unit in MP.) Thus there is one voluntary worker for each Panchayat who will be eventually responsible for planting house churches in his villages. (M.P. has 70 million people in 70,000 villages and 70,000 Christian families).

The proactive vision is to multiply house churches following the NT model of congregations downplaying five traditionally "holy cows" of local churches: the church building, official pastor (Holy man) in church, day itself is not holy, place is not holy, order of service is not holy.
The primary emphasis on multiplying house churches involves the identification and release of the five-fold ministers as per Ephesians 4:11-12: apostle, prophet, teacher, pastor, and evangelist which are complementary to each other. People Group Approach

Conclusion:

The consultation vision was to fill MP with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord as the waters cover the sea.

This consultation has served to re-orient the thinking of each of the key leaders in the state to reach out to the unreached rather than focusing on their own tiny kingdoms.

International community to God's people are invited to join the prayer efforts to see the whole state saturated with prayer. (See prayer approaches above)

For further information on the Madhya Pradesh Harvest Network: Dr. Victor Choudhrie, Coordinator at his e-mail number: Mathews@ad1.vsnl.net.in

Uttar Pradesh Harvest Consultation - Lucknow, 27-28 July 1998
Summary Report

By Dr. Raju Abraham, Coordinator Uttar Pradesh Harvest Network

The LORD is the true God; He is the living God, the Eternal King. Ask and He will give you the nations for an inheritance. For nothing is impossible with God. (Jeremiah. 10:10; Psalm. 2:8; Luke 1:37)

I. The Harvest Consultation in Uttar Pradesh

More than 180 participants from 23 districts and many different Christian churches and missions of Uttar Pradesh gathered at I.T. Christian College in the capital city of Lucknow for two days to consider the status and prospects for the harvest in Uttar Pradesh (UP). UP is the most populous state in India with over 150 million people. Uttar Pradesh has 1/7th of the population of India (but only 1/15th of its land surface).

Rev. Solomon Bodhan, Chairman of the Uttar Pradesh Harvest Network and Secretary of evangelism and missions of the Evangelical Fellowship of India (EFI) for the entire country of India, has served from his base in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh for 22 years. He best summarized the 'kairos moment' that represented this conference. He said: "There have been many large pastors conferences in UP but this is the first time people are gathering in Uttar Pradesh from so many different churches and Christian groups from so many districts for the distinct purpose of networking together to specifically reach the unreached in UP."

Participants said the duration of the conference was too short. They wanted more time to fellowship together and asked that in the future there be more time to share and encourage each other with what was happening. They recognized a key aspect of the Network was SHARING, which has three key features: Sharing of Fellowship, Sharing of Information and Sharing of Resources. Practical steps were considered by the UP Network committee to take forward the suggestions of the participants.

II. The Harvest Field of Uttar Pradesh

UP is bigger than either of India's neighbours Pakistan and Bangladesh. If it were a separate country Uttar Pradesh would be the 7th largest country in the world. It has large numbers of unreached people groups. It has appalling social and health parameters. Many areas are 20-30 years behind other parts of India. It is plagued by a chronically unstable political situation.

Spiritual strongholds dominate the state. The most revered Hindu and Buddhist shrines and places of pilgrimage are in this region--Varanasi, Haridwar, Rishikesh, Mathura, Allahabad and Ayodhya. Detailed spiritual maps of the spiritually significant cities in the region are being prepared.

III. The Harvest Force in Uttar Pradesh

Only 0.17 % (200,000) of the population is reported as Christian. Approximately half the Christians in UP are Roman Catholics and 90 % of the rest are nominal. There is however an Evangelical or

Charismatic Christian presence in all of UP's present districts. The potential of these churches represents less than 5000 Christian families in the 7 urban centers. Preliminary reports of the harvest force survey in progress by the UP Network research unit estimates that there are less than 500 Christian workers working among unreached people groups. There are, however, some encouraging signs. Presbyterians report growing churches among the BALMIKIS, a people group numbering nearly 5 million in UP in 19 districts. They report 366 pastors and a membership of over 140,000.

Independent Believers Assemblies based in Lucknow have in the last decade planted churches in 7 districts. Indian Pentecostal Churches report movement into the kingdom in moderate numbers around Varanasi among the Dalit-Chamars and around Lucknow among Awadhi speaking Dalits. YWAM and others have seen responsiveness in the Dalit-CHAMARS in Eastern and Central Uttar Pradesh as well. Independent Charismatic and Pentecostal churches report enlarging of their ministries in Jhansi among Chamars and Ambedkerites.

IV. The Harvest Methods that are working in Uttar Pradesh

A. People Group Approach

The growth of the church in India can only happen if we grasp the thorny and complex problem of reaching People Groups. We have had to understand what a people group is--essentially that members of a People Group have a sense of geographic location, a sense of identity or 'we' feeling, and a partially shared social system. In Uttar Praedesh we have studied carefully the people group approach and have adopted the conclusions of the
Anthropological Society of India in defining people groups as follows: in India, a people group is a caste, a community or a tribe that has at least the following characteristics--they only marry among themselves, they see themselves as distinct from others, and others identify them as being distinctive, they share similar customs, food and dress. Many of them have similar occupations (e.g., Dhobis), but this is becoming less common as modernization occurs. They may not all speak the same language. The first three are essential to be identified as a distinct people group in India.

The knowledge of a group's self-perception and its perception by others is relevant for developing outreach strategies and moving towards an understanding of the groups God has called us to reach.

B. Social Impact through community health and Hospitals to uplift general health

The stark reality of discrimination in modern India is overwhelming. There are communities that are still not allowed to use basic amenities like the village well, and are treated like sub-humans. Discrimination is endemic in Indian society. 21% or 1 in 5 of the 150 million people in Uttar Pradesh are from oppressed people groups who call themselves DALITS (oppressed).

Medical mission is thriving in Uttar Pradesh. Twenty doctors, nurses, health workers and church planters came to the conference. Emmanuel Hospital Association, a federation of 13 denominations with six hospital and development projects in seven districts of UP, was at the conference. They reported large number of Dalits coming to the Lord in eastern UP and seven churches planted around their hospitals and projects in Western UP.

World Vision India reported area development projects with committed Christians in 4 of UP's districts. They have taken on prayer as a major requirement in Social Action. They are also deeply committed to long term spiritual ministry.

C. Focused prayer in relation to catalytic spiritual events

Recently God's power was released at the famous Hindu festival in which millions pursue their salvation. Starting over a year ago in April 1997 groups of intercessor/worshipers met regularly in India and in different parts of the world asking God to reveal himself at the gigantic Kumbh Mela Festival. Some met every day for prayer. Every three weeks they traveled to Haridwar where the Kumbh Mela was to be held and prayed there. They met every month for twenty-four of continuos worship with fasting to discern the mind of God in Prayer. Every month they prayer walked one of the major roads into the city. During the high bathing days they fasted and prayed in the city. God did mighty things. There was dissention and violent fighting between sadhus, the Hindu holy men, and a dramatic drop in the expected number of pilgrims (from the 20 million expected to 3 million, finally). Considerable financial loss to businesses was the result. A massive outreach coordinated by 10 agencies is an amazing example of unity and networking among believers.

D. Christian Literature Distribution

One result of the prayer was the mobilization of over 600 young people from 15 states in India for outreach at the Kumbh Mela. They spread out to 26 cities of UP that were along connecting roads to Haridwar, and during the outreach distributed 5 million gospel packets in 11 Indian languages. One of the people groups showing interest has been the 15 million strong YADAV people group. 20,000 Bible correspondence courses and an active involvement in church planting among the Yadavs is the result.

Other literature outreaches were reported by Every Home for Christ which has 23 workers in six districts with 11 teams. They report 2017 Christ groups in the state. They report THAKURS a dominating people group in Eastern UP turning to the Lord. We learnt that the New Testament has now been translated into Gharwali, a language of 2.5 million speakers. Active work is being done in other major languages, e.g., Bundeli (10 million speakers), Bhojpuri (25 million in UP).

E. Contextualized Approaches for Communicating the Gospel message

The key to transforming a people group in Christ is transforming their worldview. Representatives from the PREM Institute reported a story telling approach to present Christ. The history of redemption, beginning with the book of Genesis, can effect a person's understanding of the world, which prepares him for understanding the person and ministry of Jesus. A curriculum is being developed for studying and re-telling these key stories of the Bible in such a way that a semi-literate person could easily understand and retell the story. This will facilitate people groups coming to Christ.

V. The Harvest Strategy for Uttar Pradesh (and N. India)—Conceptual Development

The acronyms PLUG (People Groups, Languages, Urban Centers, Geographic strategies) PREM (Prayer, Research, Equipping, and Mobilization), and PEPSI (Pastoral care, Expository Preaching and Social Impact).

PLUG

1. People groups -75 people groups have been identified - 5 of them are over 10 million, 30 are over 100,000, and 40 are over 10,000. UP Network is looking to partner with national and international agencies in developing Unreached People Group advocates.
2. Languages - There are 10 key languages in UP. Hindi, Urdu, Bhojpuri, Awadhi, Braj, Bundeli, Gharwali, Kumaoni, Hindustani, Jaunsari. Among believers of at least 7 of these language groups, worship is hardly conducted in their own language. Hindi is generally used. Attempts to facilitate worship in heart languages are being pursued.
3. Urban - 40 key urban centres have been identified as strategic. It is hoped that in partnership with United Prayer Track many of them will be part of 'PRAYING THROUGH THE WINDOW IV' initiative.
4. Geographical - There are 75 major districts in UP with a population of roughly 2 million each. Each district is divided into subdistrict units, called blocks, with roughly 100, 000 population, which include about 100 villages each. There are nearly 900 blocks in UP and nearly 100, 000 villages in the whole state.

UP Network has started the process of International Partnership in PREM, and PEPSI.

PREM

1. PRAYER -Dr Zacharias Fomum of Cameroon has taken prayer conferences in Dehradun, Varanasi and Allahabad. This year (1998) he will be doing advance conferences and others in Lucknow, Allhabad and Varansi. Nearly 500 have so far gone through prayer training in UP (2000 in North India). In partnership with Intercessors International, basic level prayer conferences have been conducted in Dehradun district where with 100 participants. More are planned with People Information Network, Co Springs.
2. RESEARCH - Intensive research by the UP research group have contributed to handbooks in Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh, Haryana and Rajasthan. They are in close partnership with Global Mapping International, Light International, DAWN and Foreign Mission Partnership.
3. EQUIPPING - A staff member, formerly of US Center for World Mission, explains new approaches to outreach using story telling.
4. MOBILIZATION- Seeking partnership in Unreached People Group Advocacy- already national and international agencies have adopted 5 people groups in Uttar Pradesh for Advocacy.

PEPSI

1. PASTORAL CARE-in partnership with The Christian Counselling and Educational Foundation -Philadelphia. Courses have started in June 1998 training frontline pastors in Biblical counselling and interpersonal relationships.
2. EXPOSITORY PREACHING - In partnership with The Proclamation Trust, London, pastors train Hindi speaking pastors in simple expository preaching. More partneships are planned with the US based World Harvest Mission. More partneships are needed for 15 other U P cities.
3. SOCIAL IMPACT In Dec 1997 in partnership with All Nations Christian College in Ware, England and The Jubilee Centre, Cambridge England, the first conference to help Christian

leaders think through the social implications of their faith was held. More regular conferences are planned from 1999.

For further information and a fuller report contact Dr. Raju Abraham,
106347,3175@compuserve.com

The following reports are available on Email 1) A fuller UP Harvest network report 2) Report on the Kumbh Mela 3) Report on Holistic Mission in Uttar Pradesh 4) Report on Prayer and Worship initiatives in Uttar Pradesh 5) Report on the House of Prayer for Uttar Pradesh 6) Unreached People Groups Advocacy for UP 7) PREM Institute initiatives for UP and North India 8) The Unreached, Our Most Urgent Challenge.

The Harvest is Ripe in Bihar:

Bihar state consultation on unreached peoples

Patna 28th-30th July 1998

S. D. Ponraj, Co-ordinator Bihar Out-Reach Network

Introduction:

The harvest is ripe in Bihar. This was clear from reports as met together in the last few days of July 1998 with 150 church and mission leaders from throughout our state. Spiritual breakthroughs are taking place among the Maltos, the Santalis, and Bhojpuri and in North Bihar and other places. The spiritual atmosphere appears to be open in Bihar in the midst of lawlessness and a break down of society support systems in the towns, cities and villages of our state. In the past six years the number of churches in Bihar has increased by 800.

I. Why can we conclude that the harvest is ripe in Bihar!

1. Several years of prayer and faithful preaching of the gospel has resulted in good response. Thousands of people both in India and outside India have been praying for Bihar. Many of them were particularly praying for North Bihar and the Bhojpuri, Maithili and Magahi speaking people. The Lord has answered their prayers. The hearts of the people have been prepared to listen to the gospel. Another reason is the faithful preaching of the gospel by both the former as well as the present missionaries, evangelists and pastors. The Lord has honoured their preaching and opened the hearts of the people to respond. Even though there is still the need to sow the seed of the gospel yet in many parts of Bihar today it is the harvest time, people are coming to know the Lord and churches are being planted.

2. The Church in Bihar is growing. As a result of this good response from the people for the gospel the existing churches are growing and new churches are being planted. It is estimated that the Christian population in Bihar is 2% (officially 1.06%) which means nearly two million Christians, which includes both Protestants and Roman Catholics. According to a recent research, there are about 2500 churches (congregations). There are churches in all the 55 districts of Bihar. Out of 60,000 villages there are Christians in over 2000 villages. In 1992 there were 1700 churches and in 1998 there are about 2500. In six years about 800 new churches have been planted. That is one new church every two weeks compared to one new church every 8 weeks for the years leading up to 1992. Praise is to the Lord!

3. Several new mission agencies have started their work in Bihar in recent years. There are now about 60 mission agencies and organisations working in Bihar. In 1992 there were 40 agencies and 20 have newly entered (or started) into Bihar mission field. Bihar Christians themselves have started some of them. For example Jagat Jyoti which works in co-operation with CNI, Soul Winning Mission and New India Evangelistic Association which works in Purnia. Some of the older mission agencies also are seriously considering coming back and Youth With A Mission is one such mission. This is a welcome development.

4. The focus of the ministry is now ‘church planting’ and not just evangelism. In the past, several missions and churches have faithfully sown the seed of the gospel through literature, radio, film and

public meetings. Many of them never thought of going for harvesting and planting churches. In one way the sowing was needed at that time. Teaching on church planting and church growth, by seminars and books, in recent years have resulted in giving a new focus on mission. It is focused not just on evangelism but also on conversion, baptism and planting churches. This is one of the reasons for the increase of churches in Bihar.

5. Importance is given for equipping God's people for mission and church planting. In recent years several new training programmes have been started in Bihar. For example Gospel for Asia Training Centre in Ranchi, School of Evangelism by North India IBL, Bihar School of Evangelism at Madhupur, FMPB Leadership Training Institutes for Santa's and Maltos, Missionary Training Programmes in Siwan (by EFC) and at Madhubani (by GEMS) and the AG Church Extension Bible School in Ranchi. Bihar Outreach Network has introduced GRCP training in Bihar. And also we have introduced Portable Bible School programme by Evangelism Resources for the training of lay leaders in Bihar. There are proposals to start at least one training programme for each divisions of Bihar (12 divisions) in the coming years. One will be started in Patna immediately after this consultation sponsored by Asian Partners. We praise God for these developments.

6. Churches and missions are now more willing for co-operation and partnership than in the past. This is clearly seen how the main line churches co-operate and help the indigenous missions. For example, Friends Missionary Prayer Band works in partnership with Church of North India-Patna Diocese and Chotanagpur Diocese. Again FMPB also works in partnership with other missions like EFICOR, Navjeevan Seva Mandal. This is one of the key factors for the successful work of FMPB in South Bihar. Campus Crusade for Christ has works in partnership with several missions. We praise God for such co-operation and partnership in Bihar. Every mission should follow these examples if it wants to be effective.

Another area of co-operation is at the state level. Bihar Out-Reach Network was initiated in the year 1992 and was formally launched in 1995. Leaders from various denominations and missions have come together and given their leadership to this movement. We praise and thank God for the co-operation and support from church and mission leaders for this network. There is a strong sense of feeling that God's people should come together to succeed in our task of reaching the unreached in Bihar. Praise the Lord because it is His doing.

7. There is an increasing awareness for field survey and research. In recent years churches and missions in Bihar have begun to realise the need for field survey and research for effective planning. Bihar Network has taken up the Harvest Force and the Harvest Field survey and we see increasing support for these projects. Church and mission leaders are willing to share their information for these two projects when we approach them. Some of them said that they didn't have the information but are willing to collect them from their workers and give to us. The Bihar Christian Directory is the outcome of these efforts.

8. More importance is given for strategic prayer and intercession. Church and mission leaders have begun to realise the importance of prayer for mission and evangelism. Many individual Christians, churches and missions spend regular prayer time. Prayer seminars, intercessory prayers, fasting and prayer sessions were conducted in Patna and Ranchi in the recent years. We are thankful to God for the praying teams from South Korea and Bangalore who visited Patna and Ranchi for mobilising God's

people for prayer. Bihar Out-Reach Network is bringing out a bi-monthly prayer bulletin giving opportunity for God's people to pray for Bihar.

9. There is a growing awareness for making evangelistic strategies, plans and setting goals. In the past several churches and missions were working on 'hit and run' evangelism without proper focus, strategy or goals. But now the situation has changed. For example, several missions and churches have adapted 'people group approach' and are concentrating on one or two specific people groups. The Assembly of God Church has set a goal of planting 100 churches by AD 2000 and Gospel Echoing Missionary Society has taken up placing workers in 500 PIN codes areas by AD 2000.

10. There is a greater national and international concern for the evangelisation of Bihar. Slowly Bihar State is taking a centre place in the national and international concern. In India the secular media's projection of Bihar as a 'bad state' has created more concern among God's people especially in South India. National and international concern in terms of prayer and financial support for Bihar was raised by several networks and mission agencies like North India Harvest Network, India Missions Association, the AD 2000 Movement, Unreached Peoples Program of MARC, DAWN Ministries, Foreign Mission Foundation and main line denominations such as the Presbyterian Churches in US. We praise God for those who are concerned for the evangelisation of Bihar.

II. What is hindering the harvest in Bihar!

1. Most of the churches in Bihar are nominal and do not have the vision and burden for reaching the unreached people of Bihar. Only a few churches and small denominations are actively involved in evangelism and church planting. Otherwise much of the evangelistic work is done by missions and para-church agencies. If we want to see the evangelisation of Bihar, the whole church must be actively involved in mission and evangelism.

2. There is unequal distribution of Christians and Christian workers. 75% of the Christians in Bihar are in the 18 districts of the southern regions of Chotanagpur and Santal Parganas. The remaining 37 districts have a few Christians mostly in the small towns. In the thousands of villages there is no Christian presence. Again out of 1800 PIN Code areas only 600 of them have Christian workers. It is estimated that there are about 1800 Christian workers in Bihar. But they are located in 600 PIN Code areas only. That means there are more than one worker in several PIN Code areas. This is one of the major reasons for the delay in the evangelisation of Bihar.

3. Missions and churches have concentrated on the responsive tribal people instead of giving equal importance to other people groups as well. 'Reaching the Responsive People' is a good strategy. But 'Reaching the Unreached people' is also an important and good strategy and therefore equal importance should be given to both. While harvesting the responsive people sowing must be done among the unreached people. That is how the whole of Bihar could be reached with the gospel.

4. Some of the major missions have not entered the Bihar mission field. Some of the major missions like Indian Evangelical Team, Blessing Youth Mission, Indian Evangelical Mission, Youth With A Mission, Every Creature Crusade, to name a few, do not have work in Bihar. They may have good

reasons for not entering Bihar, but because of this the evangelisation of Bihar is delayed. On behalf of Bihar Outreach Network we appeal to these and other missions to come to Bihar.

5. Cross-cultural missionaries have not trained and used enough local workers / leaders. Much of the local evangelism and church planting is done by the local evangelists, even though the cross cultural missionaries initiate the pioneering work, support, supervise and guide the work. Whereever this is followed the work is effective. But in many places the cross cultural missionaries themselves try to do everything instead of training and deploying the local evangelists and leaders. The priority task of any missionary should be to find, teach, train and use the local workers. This is not happening every where in Bihar.

6. Social, economic, cultural and political factors continue to hinder the effectiveness of the gospel. The vast population of 97 million people is a major problem to deal. There is a constant tension between different castes and religious communities, several times resulting in large-scale bloodshed and breakdown of law and order. The diversity of castes, languages, religions and people groups pose challenge to our evangelistic strategies. Widespread corruption, poverty and illiteracy cause us to rethink our priorities in mission. Constant power crisis, regular communication breakdown, poor transport facilities and no proper roads and other such problems seriously question the effectiveness of our ministry.

III. What we propose to do to reap the harvest together

Declaration: **Consultation on Unreached Peoples of Bihar, July 28-30, 1998.**

As Church leaders, Mission executives and Christian workers who have gathered for the Consultation on Unreached People Groups, July 28-30, 1998, we solemnly give our consent to the following.

1. We believe that God Almighty desires that every man be saved from eternal damnation and come to a saving knowledge of Jesus Christ His Son, who is the only hope of redemption for the unevangelized peoples of the world; which also includes the unevangelized peoples of Bihar state, India.

2. We confess that as churches and mission organisations placed in Bihar, we have for long, fallen short in our efforts to effectively reach this state with the Gospel, through lack of unity, focused strategy, collective prayer and wholehearted resolve.

3. We are encouraged to observe that God by the power of His Spirit, is bringing about renewal and refreshing in this state, as reported by convincing reports of significant people movements and conversions to the Christian faith occurring in Bihar, which once termed the "graveyard of missions" - has now become a "fruitful vineyard for missions."

4. We have now come to understand that there are still 1100 unreached pin codes representing 100 unreached people groups within the state of Bihar, which are yet to hear and respond to the Good News of Jesus Christ; beckoning us to plant 9500 additional churches in needy and hitherto least evangelised areas, with a goal to provide at least one Christian worshipping community for at least five surrounding villages.

5. We recognise that adequate training, equipping, strategic deployment of the harvest force is vital to the fulfilment of this vision; and that holistic mission as modelled by our Lord must be the hallmark of our Christian service in this economically needy state.

6. We appreciate the prophetic mantle placed upon the AD 2000 & Beyond Movement to stir up the Church world wide towards an eager expectation of the fulfilment of the Great Commission at this time; and acknowledge their significant efforts to encourage and motivate the Church in Bihar to now "Arise and Build."

7. We humbly pledge ourselves to take the Gospel to every person in Bihar, with a commitment to provide an opportunity to all, to hear and to respond to the free gift of eternal Salvation offered only through our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. We dedicate ourselves today to work towards the adopting and commissioning of work in all 1100 unreached pin codes by the year 2000. We also hereby give ourselves wholeheartedly over the next ten years, to the planting of 9500 new churches/ or a church for every five villages, in fulfilment of Jesus' mandate, through unity of purpose, clarity of vision, determined zeal and undaunting resolve, to see a new day dawn amongst the peoples of Bihar.

8. We appeal to Churches, Mission bodies and other Christian organisations represented internationally, to participate in this new move of the Spirit of God in Bihar; through fervent intercessory prayer, effective partnership and mutual encouragement; let us see by faith a day in the near future, when in the state of Bihar every knee will bow and every tongue will confess, to the glory of the Father - that Jesus is indeed Lord! Amen!

* * *

For more information write S.D. Ponraj at: The Co-ordinator, Bihar Out Reach network, 10/1-A New Patliputra Colony, Patna, Bihar – 800 013, India
E-mail is: ponraj@md2.vsnl.net.in

It's time to reach 230 million Bangalis: International Consultation on the Bengali People
Calcutta, 31 July-2 August 1998

By Susanta Patra, Coordinator of consultation and Mission Calcutta 2000

Introduction:

How do we work together to present the gospel to an estimated 230 million Bengalis worldwide? That was the question for 250 carefully selected participants from thirteen countries representing churches, indigenous and international missions in the first ever international consultation on reaching the Bengali people.

Thirty-two of the church and mission leaders from Bangladesh represented the challenge of reaching 130 million mainly Bengali Muslims in their country. There were participants from Delhi where more than one million Bengalis—mainly Muslims—have taken up many influential positions in the federal government. Mission leaders appealed for reaching the two million Bengalis in the state of Tripura among which there are less than Bengali 100 Christians. Several mission leaders came from the West Bengal State with its 70 million people. Most people were coming from Calcutta.

The consultation opened with a concert of prayer the first evening led by Dev Sarkar and other younger leaders. Prayer prevailed throughout the three days. Over 500 lay leaders participated at a breakfast calling for commitment to win the Bengalis for Christ. Almost 100 made first-time commitments to work to reach Bengalis. At the closing rally more than 1000 joined hands in a prayer commitment after the declaration was read. A sense of unity and urgency compelled all to expect great things from God and attempt great things for God in reaching the massive Bengali world.

Susanta Patra challenged all at the final rally: By the year 2000 we are trusting God for at least one church in every one of the estimated 200 Bengali people groups around the world and a church planting movement in every city in which there are a large number of Bengalis. We were called upon to expect God's surprises, that every home is a potential church and every need an opportunity for God to answer fervent focused prayer.

In order to reach Bengalis worldwide four workshops were held to help to focus on the people groups, the geographic areas, prayer and churches in revival.

From the outset the definition of Bengali was an issue. Who is the Bengali? The Bengali is a person who speaks Bengali and follows the Bengali cultural heritage (food, habits, clothes, song, dance, drama, etc.). The Bengali is a person who takes great pride in his linguistic heritage. The Bengali community can be classified into religious, caste and tribal groups.

Consultation Chairman, Mr. Peter Bose noted three major obstacles to reaching the Bengalis: 1) pride, 2) culture rooted in demonic strongholds, and 3) the independent nature of the Bengali people. Mission Calcutta and Reach Bengal chairman Dr. A. S. Raj added four more: 4) philosophy, 5) ideologies/religions, 6) clinging to many gurus and 7) Marxism.

I. What stimulated hope for the vision for reaching all Bengalis?

Mission Calcutta 2000 results fueled expectations that reaching all Bengalis is doable. Foundational to the consultation process was the strength of the organization, vision and accomplishments of Mission Calcutta 2000. Chairman Dr. Raj reported in the opening session of the way God has blessed the efforts of Mission Calcutta 2000. In 1992 the Reach Bengal Movement was started out of which Mission Calcutta 2000 Network began two years later.

The Network aimed to establish a church in each of the city's 93 postal code zones by the year 2000. When the Network was launched, 69 of those zones had no Christian witness. Today there are worshipping centers in each of these pincodes. Halelluyah! Mission Calcutta's second objective was to present the gospel message to every person in the city by 2000 AD. In 1998 alone 700 special volunteers gave themselves to the task of presenting the gospel to the families of Calcutta house by house by dsitributing a package of Christian literature. 800,000 homes were reached representing some four million of the twelve million residents of Calcutta. Thirdly, Mission Calcutta aimed to place at least one Christian worker in each of the 65 different ethnolinguistic people groups within the city. At the beginning of the project, only ten of the groups had been reached. New strategies have been initiated, including the publishing of evangelistic literature in several languages and the showing of a Christian film in several areas. Today, Christian workers are already in place in each of 42 of these people groups.

II. Why is there conviction that it is spiritual harvest time for the Bengalis?

We are in harvest time. It is evident that God is at work among the Bengali people in a unique way. On 27th August 1997, we received a letter from Rev. D. K. Sarkar, the Secretary oif the Reach Bengal Movement. “I count it a great joy to have the privilege of writing to you. God is moving in West Bengal. I am sure you are very much aware of these realities in your ministry in our state. Evidence of God’s moving in West Bengal includes the following:

1. There is a global awareness and burden to pray for the Bengali people. There are prayer initiatives in Brazil, Argentina, Canada, U.S.A., New Zealand and many others countries.

2. There are seven different prayer movements continuing in West Bengal include all night prayer, fasting, concerts, mid-day prayer, prayer walks. Just one of these movements involves 650 focused prayer groups.

3. The response to the gospel in different missions has grown almost to 600%. For example, if one mission had a response of ten baptisms during 1991 in 1996 that would have increased to sixty.

4. Unity among the Christians with love and respect for one another is being seen between the denominations and missions (though not yet complete). In fact, a monthly meeting has been established, called a transdenominational service, which is being held in both Calcutta and the districts, in which almost every denomination participates for worship and prayer.

5. Bengalis of national importance are getting converted both in West Bengal and other cities of India. Recently a Bengali of national prominence gave his life to Jesus and through his witness thirty-six influential associates have come to Christ.

6. Different churches and missions are pioneering several untouched areas of West Bengal. Naren Pal is working in Raiganj town in Dinajpur District. Raiganj is one of the rapidly growing towns in West Bengal. Naren works among educated Bengalis. Previous to his arrival, there were no churches in Raiganj. Within the last two years, Naren has established four worship centers in this growing town.

Oh, my list would go on and on. It is indeed true that God is moving in Bengal. Therefore let us not lose heart, but strive with all our might to reach our state for God.

III. Why is it so important to reach the Bengali People for whom Christ died?

1. Bengali People are one of the most influential people in Northern India. The Bengali People's contribution in the establishment of India both before and after independence is noteworthy. They played a key role in the freedom movement and later in nation building by successfully arguing for the inclusion in the constitution of the freedom of religion as a fundamental right of people of all religions. Our people are considered highly influential in the area of music, dance, drama and other cultural activities.

2. Bengali People are one of the most neglected people in the work of the gospel. In Bangladesh there are about 70,000 villages, but a definite gospel witness in only 6 to 7 thousand villages. Over 100 million Bengali people live in India covering the whole belt of northern and eastern India. In rural West Bengal, Assam and Tripura, there is still very little or no gospel work. For example, almost two thirds of the population of Tripura is Bengali but it is untouched with the gospel. The rest of our population lives in urban centers with no opportunity to hear the gospel.

3. Bengali People are one of the most strategic people. Bengalis are the seventh largest linguistic people in the world. Missiologically, Bengalis are known as a gateway people of Northern India, which means that if the Bengalis are won with the gospel, it will take much less time for many other people groups to be reached with the gospel. Many great missionaries began their work among the Bengali people with this view in mind. It has been estimated that if one Bengali genuinely comes to know Christ, he will influence at least fifteen people in the same year of his conversion.

4. Bengali People are one of the most reachable people. Often, we fall into a thinking that Bengali People are very difficult to reach. But the lack of response is actually due to an ineffective presentation of the gospel.

We have failed to reach the Bengalis because we have not faced the fact that our people concluded that Christianity was a religion for white people. It was associated with the British people, ruling over us who often did not maintain a godly life style. For a Bengali, being a Christian meant to be a traitor to our motherland. The English language was widely used in spreading the gospel, and this played another damaging role in the growth of the Church. Contextualisation of the gospel was almost nil.

The practice of "Mission Compound Christianity" did not allow the gospel to go to the interior parts of Bengali society. The practice of "rice Christianity" introduced nominalism into the Bengali churches. More people became Christians for help and not a true change in life. The entrance of communism and communist teaching in our educational institutions obstructed the growth of the Christian gospel.

The gospel was not presented to the Bengali people based on their felt needs and worldviews. Bengali people love to think in contrasting forms of thought, and philosophy. Many such realities have been ignored while making a strategy to present the gospel to the Bengali People. If the gospel is presented specifically for the Bengali People and their mind set, I believe our people would be the most responsive people in the world.

IV. What was the binding covenant to reach Bengali people committed to at the Consultation?

1. We affirm our faith in the one-eternal God who is Creator, Ruler and Sustainer of the whole world, the Father, Son and the Holy Spirit.
2. We affirm the divine inspiration, accuracy, infallibility and authority of the Bible as the only written Word of God and its power to accomplish God's purposes for salvation.
3. We affirm that there is only one Savior and only one gospel although there are a multiplicity of approaches to reaching the Bengali People Group around the world.
4. We affirm that the good news that Jesus Christ died for our sins and was raised up again is to be spread throughout the Bengali world and also that the offer for the forgiveness of sins and the gift of the Holy Spirit is to be proclaimed to every Bengali.
5. We affirm to develop strategies to counter spiritual strongholds that control the Bengali people and establish target intercession for Bengalis all over the world so that the evangelization may be complete and effective among the seventh largest people group in the world.
6. We affirm to be united in our efforts to reach out to the growing Bengali population in urban centers, the disillusioned urban youth, the urban middle class and the urban poor with the gospel of Jesus Christ and to communicate effectively the absolute truth of the gospel to the educated and urban Bengalis in the midst of conflicting claims of ideological diversity in this post-modern period.
7. There are more than 230 million Bengalis around the world and most of them are yet to be evangelized. We affirm that we will use all available means so that by the earliest possible time, every Bengali will have the opportunity to hear, understand and receive the good news. This calls for imaginative pioneering methods to win our own people.
8. We pray for leaders of nations where Bengalis live that they will guarantee peace, justice and liberty and freedom to practice and propagate our faith among our own people group.
9. We affirm our faith in the power of the Holy Spirit who bears witness to Christ our Lord. We call upon Bengali Christians worldwide to pray for a mighty outpouring of God's Holy Spirit upon the Bengali people group and that millions of our people who call upon His Name will be saved.
10. We affirm our faith in the bodily and visible return of Christ Jesus in power and glory to complete the work of salvation and his judgment.

WE, the participants of this International Christian Consultation for the Bengali People, Calcutta, solemnly pledge to God and to each other to pray, plan and to work together

Conclusion:

The heartbeat of the International Consultation is to present the gospel to every Bengali in a way that he or she can understand. This is the hour for outreach to the Bengali worldwide. God has done an amazing work through His people through the Mission Calcutta 2000 action plan. Many indicators from the Reach Bengal Movement reflect the fact that the fields are ripe for harvest. The Bengali is an important people to reach as a major potential force for mission. A covenant sealed the commitment to reach the Bengali world for Christ with a sense of a passion and urgency.

A systematic follow-up action plan has been prepared to fulfill this covenant agreement. The steering committee is meeting within the week to assess the consultation results and set in motion concrete steps for following through. One of the first steps will involve gathering some fifteen Bengali Christian intellectuals from around the world to prepare an effective strategy to fulfill the follow-up action plan.

International partners with a heart to reach the Bengalis are invited to join us in this global effort. We need your prayers; people and financial resources to collaborate in this global God-given enterprise to see all Bengalis presented the gospel of Christ and a church for every people group among the Bengalis.